

a woodcut for each of the follies undertaken by the various fools. Figure 5.4 shows one such Dürer woodcut. It depicts men wearing ass-eared head-dresses clinging to Fortuna's wheel, which Fortuna's hand "puppets." As they ascend up the wheel, the men turn into asses; at the apex, the ass reaches for the sun; and, as they descend, they turn back into men. The woodcut seems to be a commentary on our ignorance of the role of luck and randomness in life, and the inevitable end to *Regno* (I reign). At *Regno*, instead of preparing for *Sum sine regno* (I am without a kingdom), we reach for the sun, imagining that we'll continue to ascend or remain at the pinnacle forever.

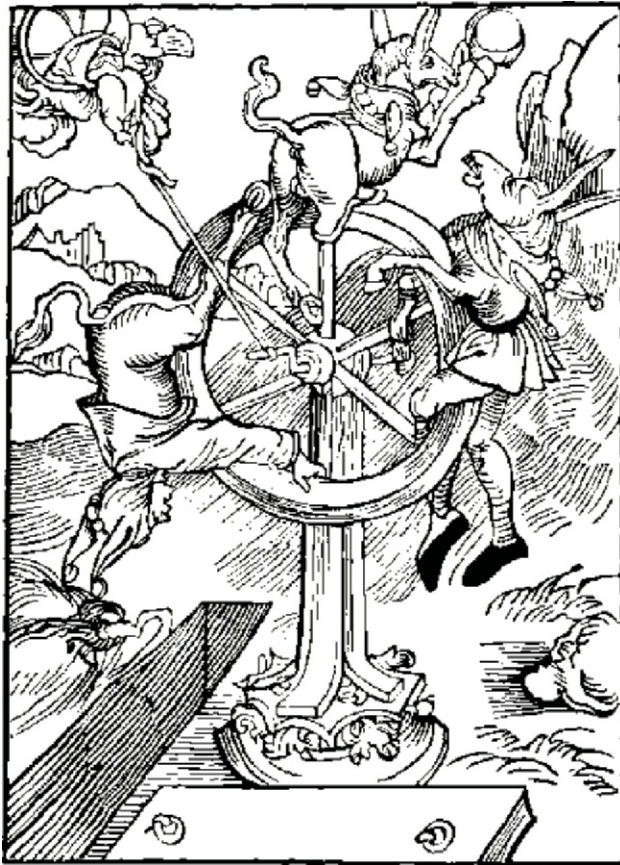


FIGURE 5.4 Albrecht Dürer's *The Wheel of Fortune* from Sebastian Brant's *Ship of Fools* (1494)

Source: Sebastian Brant. *The Ship of Fools*. Translated by Alexander Barclay. (Edinburgh: William Paterson) 1874.²⁰